CS577 - Introduction to Algorithms 4 Credit – Fall 2025

Section 001
Lecture: TR 9:30 - 10:45 MORGRIDGE 1570
Discussions:
DIS-311: W 08:50 - 09:40 MORGRIDGE 2516
DIS-312: W 09:55 - 10:45 MORGRIDGE 2522
DIS-313: W 11:00 - 11:50 MORGRIDGE 2532
DIS-314: W 12:05 - 12:55 MORGRIDGE 2516
DIS-315: W 14:25 - 15:15 MORGRIDGE 2522
DIS-316: W 15:30 - 16:20 ENGR HALL 3032
DIS-317: W 15:30 - 16:20 MICROBIAL SCI 1420
DIS-318: W 8:50 - 9:40 ENGR HALL 2239
DIS-319: W 15:30 - 16:20 ENGR HALL 2534

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Calendar Description

Basic paradigms for the design and analysis of efficient algorithms: greed, divide-and-conquer, dynamic programming, reductions, and the use of randomness. Computational intractability including typical NP-complete problems and ways to deal with them. Enroll Info: None

Specific Learning Outcomes

Students successfully completing this course will be able to:

- Design and analyze efficient algorithms based on the paradigms of divide-and-conquer, dynamic programming, and greedy.
- Formulate abstractions of computational problems, and design and analyze efficient reductions between computational problems.
- Know, understand, and apply paradigmatic algorithms and reductions dealing with numbers, strings, graphs, and networks.
- Recognize computational intractability, demonstrate NP-hardness, and understand its repercussions.

Texts

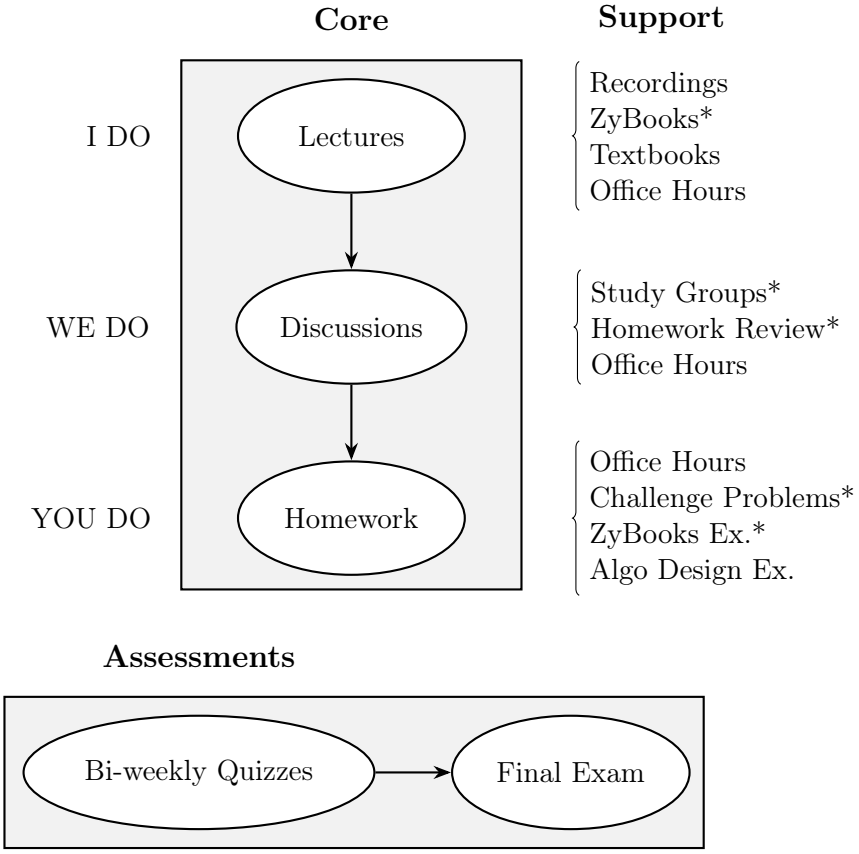
All the texts are optional. *Algorithm Design* by Kleinberg and Tardos should be considered the main text, but, we will also provide references to other texts. As to why, I think Jeff Erickson says it best in the frontmatter of his online *Algorithms* textbook:

> "Please do not restrict yourself to this or any other single reference. Authors and readers bring their own perspectives to any intellectual material; no instructor "clicks" with every student, or even with every very strong student. Finding the author that most effectively gets their intuition into your head takes some effort, but that effort pays off handsomely in the long run."

- **Kleinberg and Tardos. *Algorithm Design.* Addison Wesley, 2006.** The main textbook for 577.
- **zyBooks COMP SCI 577: Introduction to Algorithms.** Additional resource with bonus point opportunities. zyBook code: WISCCOMPSCI577001RenaultFall2025. Registrations should be completed by Sep 30, 2025.
- **Jeff Erickson. *Algorithms.* jeffe.cs.illinois.edu/teaching/algorithms/** Free online algorithms textbook. A hardcopy, black-and-white version can be purchased from Amazon.
- **Cormen, Leiserson, Rivest, and Stein. *Introduction to Algorithms, 3rd Edition.* MIT Press, 2009.** Now with C-style pseudocode! The classic (presumably because it was the textbook I used in my intro to algorithms course) introduction to algorithms textbook.
- **Sedgewick, and Wayne. *Algorithms, 4th Edition* Pearson, 2011.** Another introduction to algorithms textbook with working Java code.

Format and Procedures

CS577 Intro to Algorithms Overview



Class Structure

The classes will be a combination of lectures, discussions and exercises. You are encouraged to ask questions throughout the class and to be engaged in the discussions. During the exercises, please feel free to engage with your peers or myself as you work on the problems.

Participation

Lectures: In order to facilitate discussions and to determine participation grades, we will use TopHat in this course. The TopHat questions will be graded on participation not correctness. The questions will be re-opened following lecture and will be open for one week after lecture. Note that the time available to answer TopHat questions will not extend past the night before the final exam.

The roster in Canvas should be automatically synced to the TopHat roster. You can find the TopHat course at:

- Section 001: `https://app.tophat.com/e/214771`.

More information on TopHat can be found at `https://it.wisc.edu/services/top-hat/`. The 80% rule will apply to the TopHat lecture questions, see below.

Discussions: Attendance will be taken for the discussion participation. For full marks, you must arrive no later than 5 minutes after the scheduled start, stay until the scheduled end, and participate in the discussion. Each discussion carries equal weight. The 80% rule will apply, see below.

Assignment Submissions

You will submit your assignments to Gradescope. They should be in pdf format with the answers written on the assignment subject itself.

You will need to register with Gradescope at `https://www.gradescope.com/`, using your wisc.edu email. *To facilitate the transfer of grades from Gradescope to Canvas,* ***please only register with your wisc.edu email*** *used by Canvas (no aliases) and not your personal email nor your cs.wisc.edu.* The course entry code is: NGJEWW.

It is your responsibility to ensure that your scans are legible, and that your assignments are submitted correctly to Gradescope. When a template is provided, you must use the provided template to submit your written work, and not alter the geometry of the template. For example, if the assignment template pdf has 5 pages, the pdf you submit should also have exactly 5 pages and solutions to the problems should be on the same pages as they were in the template pdf.

Code: Some of the assignments will ask you to code a solution to a problem. For these exercises, you can use Java, C, C++, C#, Python, or Rust (other languages may be possible, but first discuss with your instructor). When you submit your code, be sure to include a makefile that runs your program with the command `make run` - a sample makefile will be provided in Canvas. The input to the programs will be read from the console and the solution should be printed out to the console. For each coding question in assignments, there will be a Gradescope assignment that you will be required to submit all your the files (source code, makefile, etc).

Late Submissions: No late submission will count for participation, but we will be happy to provide feedback on any late submissions during office hours if requested.

Piazza

There will be a specific Piazza board for section 001 of 577. You should be automatically enrolled. Please ensure that you are able to access it.

Course Requirements

TopHat (5%)

During each lecture, there will be some TopHat questions which will be used to calculate a participation grade. Each question in a lecture will have the same weight and be graded based on participation (not correctness). In addition, questions will be made available for one week after lecture. The 80% rule will apply, see below.

Discussion Participation (5%)

Attendance will be taken for the discussion participation. For full marks, you must arrive no later than 5 minutes after the scheduled start and stay until the scheduled end. Each discussion carries equal weight. The 80% rule will apply, see below.

Students are required to attend the discussion in which they are registered to earn the discussion participation points.

Assignments (15%)

There will be one assignment per week, starting in week 1, released on Tuesday, for a total of 13 assignments (no assignment due during Thanksgiving, or released on the last week). Each assignment will carry the same overall weight, and will be due Wednesday at 11:59 pm of the next week. The assignments will be graded based on participation rather than correctness. Submitting a blank document will not be sufficient to gain participation points. Rather, each question in the assignment will be graded for participation, giving an overall participation score for the assignment.

In order to get participation points, you must submit an answer that demonstrates to the grader that you made a *reasonable* attempt to answer the question. Most questions will involve designing algorithms, working through algorithms and writing proofs. Be sure to show your work. If you are unsure how to answer a question, explain what you understand about the question, what approach you believe needs to be taken for the question, and where you are stuck. This will also earn participation credit for those questions. An answer to a question may be deemed unreasonable if certain basic elements are not included, some examples are:

- proof of correctness that just restates the algorithm;
- if only a picture is provided with no description of the reduction/algorithm/proof;
- reduction for NP-completeness done in the wrong direction.

We are grading you based on *your* participation: copying answers, or using an AI is not valid for participation marks. On any assignment where you copy any solution or use an AI for any solution, you will not receive any participation marks for the assignment. Note that this is considered plagiarism which can result in disciplinary action (see Academic Integrity below).

> "Unmerited applause a wise man rejects with contempt upon all occasions... ...By suffering himself to be applauded for what he has not performed, by assuming a merit which does not belong to him, he feels that he is guilty of a mean falsehood, and deserves, not the admiration, but the contempt of those very persons who, by mistake, had been led to admire him. It may, perhaps, give him some well-founded pleasure to find that he has been, by many people, thought capable of performing what he did not perform. But, though he may be obliged to his friends for their good opinion, he would think himself guilty of the greatest baseness if he did not immediately undeceive them. It gives him little pleasure to look upon himself in the light in which other people actually look upon him, when he is conscious that, if they knew the truth, they would look upon him in a very different light. A weak man, however, is often much delighted with viewing himself in this false and delusive light. He assumes the merit of every laudable action that is ascribed to him, and pretends to that of many which nobody ever thought of ascribing to him. He pretends to have done what he never did, to have written what another wrote, to have invented what another discovered; and is led into all the miserable vices of plagiarism and common lying. But though no man of middling good sense can derive much pleasure from the imputation of a laudable action which he never performed..."
> – Adam Smith, *The Theory of Moral Sentiments*

For each assignment, each question or enumerated subquestion with a reasonable attempt to answer will be given a participation grade of 1. No reasonable attempt to answer will be given a participation grade of 0.

For the programming question (if there is one), there will be an autograded participation mark. There will be additional autograded tests, but they are informational and will not be used for marks. Note that your code must compile, run, and terminate gracefully to receive the participation mark. If you receive the participation mark (regardless of the additional tests), you get full credit for that coding question.

Note that a coding question on an assignment is worth 1 point which is equivalent to a single question or enumerated subquestion so plan your time accordingly. The participation mark is calculated based on your program successfully completing a series of basic tests for the programming question.

The 80% rule (see below for more details) will be applied to the overall average of all the assignments, where each assignment has equal weight. As such it is always worth submitting whatever work you have completed on the assignment by the due date. No late work will be accepted.

Once the assignments are returned, you will have a limited window to submit regrade requests. This will typically be 1 week, but may be less due to course constraints, in particular, at the end of the semester.

Built-in flexibility: 80% rule

For the scores where the 80% rule applies, if your calculated score is 80% or higher, you will be credited the full points. If it is y% for $y < 80$, you will be credited $\frac{y}{100} \cdot x$ points, where y is your calculated score and x is the total points. I.e., a discussion participation score of 79% would result in 3.95 out of 5 points.

It is important to note that the 80% rule is to have built-in flexibility for all the students in the case of an unexpected situation, or McBurney flexibility accommodation. For content that uses the 80%, the expectation is that students will still attend and complete 100% of the assigned discussions, classes, and assignments. It does not mean that the expectation is that students should only complete 80% of the assigned discussions, classes, and assignments. Finally, doing less than 80% of the assigned discussions, classes, and assignments risks altering the knowledge and skills of the course, lowering the academic standards, and fundamentally altering the nature of the course.

Quizzes (30%)

There will be 6 quizzes throughout the semester (see below for exact dates). Let a be an array (0 based indexing) containing your quiz scores (out of 1), in order, from highest to lowest. The overall grades for the quizzes will be calculated as follows:

$$\text{Quizzes (out of 30)} = a[0] \cdot 15 + a[1] \cdot 8 + a[2] \cdot 4 + a[3] \cdot 2 + a[4] \cdot 1 + a[5] \cdot 0$$

These quizzes will be 30 minutes and take place in Canvas as indicated in the schedule below. All quizzes will open on Thursday and be available from Thursday at 17:45 to Friday at 17:45. The administration of the quizzes will involve proctoring via Honorlock (c.f. `https://kb.wisc.edu/luwmad/page.php?id=103206`). The quiz will only be open during this 24-hour time window. No extensions will be given, and it is the responsibility of the student to start the quiz with enough time to complete it in the given time window. It is highly recommended that students plan to take the quiz on Thursday night to allow for time to handle any potential issues. Moreover, there is a practice quiz on the Canvas site that students are strongly encourage to use to test their setup prior to each quiz.

An in-person option will also be made available the same Thursday from 17:45 - 18:15. You will need to sign-up for it in advance. The sign-up link can be found on the Canvas site. The sign up sheet will close the Wednesday before each quiz by 16:00, and will be reopened after the in-person quiz for the subsequent quizzes. In order to take the in-person, you must sign-up prior to the sign-up sheet closing. IMPORTANT NOTE: The time of the in-person quiz may need to be changed due to availability of rooms.

Note that, in addition to the 24-hour time window to take the quiz, the generous quiz aggregation is designed in part to provide built-in flexibility. Due to the logistics of the course, there will be no make-up quizzes, but note that the lowest quiz has a value of 0, and the lowest 3 quizzes have a value of only 3.

Exam (45%)

The final exam will be on Saturday, Dec 13, 2025 from 19:25 to 21:25. The exam date was known when you signed up for the course and you must ensure that you are available at the time of the exams. Exams will not given early. Alternate times will only be possible in the event of an actual conflict with another UW-Madison exam. Incompletes are only rarely offered in extreme cases such as troop deployment, or medical emergencies. Any medical excuses will require proof that can be verified as authentic. If your provide will not verify the proof, an incomplete will not be given.

It will be 2 hours and consist of 5 questions each worth 10 points. All questions answered will be graded and the final exam grade will be out of 40, making the maximum possible grade 50/40.

The exam will be open book: that is you will be permitted to bring any *non-electronic* books and notes to the exam.

Bonus Points (10%)

There are multiple opportunities for students to gain bonus points: preparing for the class by reviewing prereq material (Review Assignment and zyBook), attending the lectures in-person, going over the material related to lecture (attending study groups), seeking out feedback on work through the semester (homework reviews), seeking out additional problems (the challenge problems), and working through additional material (the optional zyBook). All the categories below in addition to earning bonus marks are examples of good student habits that can be applied to any course to help you learn the material and be more successful in the course.

None are required in order to achieve full marks in the course. The total amount of bonus points from the items enumerated below is capped at 10%. However, you are encouraged to pursue all the bonus points below. There is no 80% rule, or extensions for any of the bonus points.

Syllabus Canvas Quiz (2%):

You can earn 2% bonus marks by reading this syllabus and earning a perfect score on the Syllabus Canvas Quiz. You must complete the quiz by Sunday, Sep 7, 2025 at 23:59. You will have an unlimited number of attempts. No notes or outside material are allowed. The quiz will be controlled by Honorlock giving you a chance to test your quiz setup.

PreReq Review Assignment (up to 2%):

Read the Demonstration Proof Beyond the Possibility of Doubt: Fundamentals and Proof Techniques, review the discrete notes, and complete the Review Assignment found on Canvas. This assignment will be submitted through Gradescope. You must use the provided template. It is due Sep 15, 2025 at 23:59.

There is a template and it will be graded based on participation just like the required homework.

In-Person Lecture Attendance (up to 5%):

During lecture, we will use the TopHat attendance feature to determine attendance at each lecture. For details on how the TopHat attendance works, see `https://support.tophat.com/s/article/Student-Attendance`. The in-person attendance will be tracked via this TopHat feature only without exception. Students wishing to earn these bonus marks are responsible for ensuring that they are able to use the TopHat attendance feature. That is, to earn credit for a lecture attendance students should be in the lecture hall for the duration of the lecture, and have their devices working with the TopHat attendance feature. TopHat support can help debug any potential issues. There will be no manual adjustment of the attendances marks.

Each lecture will be equally weighted for the bonus marks. If you attend (as recorded via the TopHat attendance feature) x out of y lectures, you will receive $5 \cdot \frac{x}{y}$ bonus marks.

Attending Study Groups (up to 5%):

You can earn 5% bonus by attending a study group every week of the semester. The TA/PM will take attendance at the start of the study group. You arrive on time and stay to the end to get credit.

Each week (starting from week 2 - excluding Thanksgiving Week) will be equally weighted for the bonus marks. If you attend (as recorded by the TA/PM) study groups for x out of 13 weeks, you will receive $5 \cdot \frac{x}{13}$ bonus marks.

Homework Review (up to 5%)

You can earn up to 5% bonus by reviewing your homework with an instructor, TA, or PM. The homework review will take place after the solutions have been released and occur during drop-in office hours. You should compare your solutions to the solutions for each question and note the differences:

- Is your solution incorrect and why?
- Is there anything you missed in your solution?
- Is there an aspect of your solution that was not in the given solution?
- How could you improve your solution?

To earn the bonus marks, you need to come to the drop-in office prepared, having already reviewed the given solutions, to go through your review of the solutions with an instructor, TA, or PM. Each weekly homework will be equally weighted. If you do a homework review for x out of y assignments, you will receive $5 \cdot \frac{x}{y}$ bonus marks.

You are only able to get credit for a homework review on homework that you submitted to Gradescope. Your homework review needs to be done within a week of the grades being released. With the last assignment being an exception. The last assignment needs to be reviewed before the final exam. Also, if the office hours are particularly busy, you may be asked to come back on a different day to complete the review.

Challenge Problems (up to 5%):

You can earn up to 5% bonus by solving the biweekly challenge problems. There will be 6 challenge problems in total (released every two weeks on Wednesdays). Each of these questions are designed to be similar to exam questions. You will have one week (Wednesday after release date by 23:59) to solve the problem and submit it to Gradescope for the initial grading. Your answers should be done individually and will be graded on correctness just like the exam. The initial grading should be completed by Friday, and you will have until the following Wednesday at 23:59 to submit a revised answer. For a given challenge problem, your grade will be the maximum score of the grade of the first submission and the grade of the second submission.

Each challenge problem will be equally weighted for the bonus marks. The average of your grades across all challenge problems (0 for missed challenge problems) will be used to determine what percentage of the 5 bonus marks you earn.

Challenge Problem Schedule

Topic	First Submission Due	Rework Submission Due
Graphs	Sep 24	Oct 1
Greedy	Oct 8	Oct 15
Divide & Conquer	Oct 22	Oct 29
Dynamic Programming	Nov 5	Nov 12
Network Flow	Nov 19	Nov 26
Intractability	Dec 3	Dec 10

zyBook (up to 5%):

You can earn up to 5% bonus marks by working through the optional zyBook textbook as follows:

- Earn up to 2% by completing all the participation activities in the zyBook by Dec 10, 2025 at 23:59. If you complete x out of y participation activities, you will receive $2 \cdot \frac{x}{y}$ bonus marks.
- Earn up to 1% by completing the designated exercises from the zyBook for Chapters 1 to 7 by Sep 30, 2025 at 23:59. If you complete x out of y designated exercises, you will receive $1 \cdot \frac{x}{y}$ bonus marks.
- Earn up to 2% by completing the designated exercises from the zyBook for Chapters 8 to 24 by Dec 10, 2025 at 23:59. If you complete x out of y designated exercises, you will receive $2 \cdot \frac{x}{y}$ bonus marks.

  In Canvas, under the zyBook Exercise assignment, you will find the list of exercises to complete. They should be submitted to the Gradescope zyBook Exercise assignment for grading. They will be graded based on participation just like the required homework, and must be submitted correctly to Gradescope with the questions properly assigned to receive marks. Each question must be assigned in Gradescope to receive any credit for the question. If you do not submit the exercises correctly, you will not receive bonus credit.

  The proper submission to Gradescope is the responsibility of the student not the graders nor the instructional staff.

There is no 80% rule, or extensions for any of the zyBook bonus points. Students should have registered for zyBooks by Sep 30, 2025 to ensure access to the zyBook. It may not be possible to register for the zyBook after this date.

It is recommended to work through the zyBook with the course. zyBook Chapter to Topic Mapping:

- Ch 1 to 7: Review of discrete, CS 300/400 topics, Week 1 lecture.
- Ch 8 to 11: Greedy
- Ch 12 to 14: Divide & Conquer
- Ch 15 to 17: Dynamic Programming
- Ch 18: FFT is a Divide & Conquer algorithm
- Ch 19: Network Flow
- Ch 20: Intractability
- Ch 21 to 24: Randomization and Approximation

Final Letter Grade

We expect the grades to fit the standard UW grading scheme which is:

A	100% to 90%
AB	$<$ 90% to 85%
B	$<$ 85% to 80%
BC	$<$ 80% to 75%
C	$<$ 75% to 70%
D	$<$ 70% to 60%
F	$<$ 60% to 0%

This should only be considered a rough guide.

Grades will be scaled so that the median grade is a B (GPA 3.0).

Schedule

(This schedule is subject to change.)

Lecture and Quiz Schedule

All quizzes will open on Thursday and be available from Thursday at 17:45 to Friday at 17:45.

Week	Date	Topic	Quizzes
1	Sep 1	First class Thur, Sep 4: Course Intro, and Basics of Algorithm Analysis	
2	Sep 8	Graphs, and Greedy	
3	Sep 15	Greedy	Quiz 1 - AA, Discrete, and Graphs
4	Sep 22	Greedy, and Divide & Conquer	
5	Sep 29	Divide & Conquer	Quiz 2 - Greedy
6	Oct 6	Dynamic Programming	
7	Oct 13	Dynamic Programming	Quiz 3 - D&C
8	Oct 20	Dynamic Programming, and Network Flow	
9	Oct 27	Network Flow	Quiz 4 - DP
10	Nov 3	Network Flow, and Intractability	
11	Nov 10	Intractability	Quiz 5 - NF
12	Nov 17	Intractability	
13	Nov 24	Randomization, and *Thanksgiving*	
14	Dec 1	Randomization, and Approximation	Quiz 6 - Intractability
15	Dec 8	Last class Tues, Dec 9: Review	

Assignment Schedule

All assignments are released on Tuesday in the am, and due on the following Wednesday at 11:59 pm.

Week	Date	Due	Release
1	Sep 1		1 - Discrete Review
2	Sep 8	1 - Discrete Review	2 - Asymptotic Analysis and Graphs
3	Sep 15	2 - Asymptotic Analysis and Graphs	3 - Greedy
4	Sep 22	3 - Greedy	4 - More Greedy
5	Sep 29	4 - More Greedy	5 - Divide & Conquer
6	Oct 6	5 - Divide & Conquer	6 - More Divide & Conquer
7	Oct 13	6 - More Divide & Conquer	7 - Dynamic Programming
8	Oct 20	7 - Dynamic Programming	8 - More Dynamic Programming
9	Oct 27	8 - More Dynamic Programming	9 - Network Flow
10	Nov 3	9 - Network Flow	10 - More Network Flow
11	Nov 10	10 - More Network Flow	11 - Intractability
12	Nov 17	11 - Intractability	12 - More Intractability
13	Nov 24	*Thanksgiving*	13 - Randomization
14	Dec 1	12 - More Intractability	
15	Dec 8	13 - Randomization	

Discussion Schedule

All discussion are on Wednesdays. There is a discussion on every week of the semester.

Week	Date	Topic
1	Sep 3	Introduction: Meet TA and PM
2	Sep 10	Discrete Review
3	Sep 17	Asymptotic Analysis and Graphs
4	Sep 24	Greedy
5	Oct 1	Greedy
6	Oct 8	Divide & Conquer
7	Oct 15	Divide & Conquer
8	Oct 22	Dynamic Programming
9	Oct 29	Dynamic Programming
10	Nov 5	Network Flow
11	Nov 12	Network Flow
12	Nov 19	Intractability
13	Nov 26	Intractability
14	Dec 3	Randomization
15	Dec 10	Review

University Policies

Rules, Rights and Responsibilities

See http://guide.wisc.edu/undergraduate/#rulesrightsandresponsibilitiestext.

Academic Integrity

By enrolling in this course, each student assumes the responsibilities of an active participant in UW-Madison's community of scholars in which everyone's academic work and behavior are held to the highest academic integrity standards. Academic misconduct compromises the integrity of the university. Cheating, fabrication, plagiarism, unauthorized collaboration, and helping others commit these acts are examples of academic misconduct, which can result in disciplinary action. This includes but is not limited to failure on the assignment/course, disciplinary probation, or suspension. Substantial or repeated cases of misconduct will be forwarded to the Office of Student Conduct & Community Standards for additional review. For more information, refer to https://conduct.students.wisc.edu/academic-misconduct/.

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

McBurney Disability Resource Center syllabus statement: "The University of Wisconsin-Madison supports the right of all enrolled students to a full and equal educational opportunity. The Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), Wisconsin State Statute (36.12), and UW-Madison policy (Faculty Document 1071) require that students with disabilities be reasonably accommodated in instruction and campus life. Reasonable accommodations for students with disabilities is a shared faculty and student responsibility. Students are expected to inform faculty [me] of their need for instructional accommodations by the end of the third week of the semester, or as soon as possible after a disability has been incurred or recognized. Faculty [I], will work either directly with the student [you] or in coordination with the McBurney Center to identify and provide reasonable instructional accommodations. Disability information, including instructional accommodations as part of a student's educational record, is confidential and protected under FERPA." http://mcburney.wisc.edu/